

Trump reissues threat on Strait of Hormuz

Iran is warned to open the vital route or face worse attacks. Search for airman continues.

By SAM MEDNICK, SAMY MAGDY AND JON GAMBRELL

TEL AVIV — President Trump on Saturday again warned Iran to open the crucial Strait of Hormuz by his Monday deadline, and Tehran called his threat “unbalanced and foolish.” The search for a missing U.S. airman continued for a second day in a remote part of the Islamic Republic.

Trump has called Tehran “beaten and completely decimated” in the war, now in its sixth week, but the downing of two U.S. warplanes Friday and Iran’s call to find the “enemy pilot” have cast doubt on the president’s claims while raising the stakes.

“The doors of hell will be opened to you” if Iran’s infrastructure is attacked, Gen. Ali Abdollahi Aliabadi of the Iranian joint military command said late Saturday in response to Trump’s renewed threat, state media reported. The general in turn threatened all infrastructure used by the U.S. military in the region.

The war, which began with U.S.-Israeli strikes on Iran on Feb. 28, has killed thousands, shaken global markets, cut off key shipping routes and sent fuel prices [See Iran, A4]

At Easter, praying for regime change

Unlike Catholic leaders, Iranian Americans at a Chicago-area church are championing the war. **A6**



ATTA KENARE AFP/Getty Images



Bloomberg

A WOMAN walks through the war-damaged interior of Tehran’s Golestan Palace, top, a UNESCO World Heritage site. Above, then-Gen. Randy George with soldiers in training in November. He was fired as Army chief of staff Thursday.

Army chief’s firing at time of war adds to Pentagon turmoil

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Merely two weeks had passed since the Iran war began when Gen. Randy George, the Army’s highest-ranking officer, began sounding an alarm.

Touring a weapons depot in North Carolina, Army Chief of Staff George warned lawmakers present that the conflict’s vast and ever-growing list of targets was straining U.S. capacity — “depleting our stockpiles faster than we can replace them,” as one congressman

recalled. Since assuming Army leadership, George had made it his mission to strengthen the nation’s industrial base in anticipation of precisely this moment, when the United States would be engaged in a major war with a formidable adversary.

On Thursday, in a brief phone call, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth fired George. No reason was given, a U.S. official familiar with the matter told The Times.

The forced departure of George in the middle of a war created yet another blow to

morale inside the Pentagon, where multiple officials expressed dismay over the state of the department’s leadership. Over the past year, Hegseth has fired five sitting members of the joint chiefs of staff, with only two holdovers remaining in their posts.

“Whenever you have a change in leadership, military or otherwise, there is bound to be some churn in information management,” one U.S. official said, granted anonymity to speak candidly. “So what you’re doing, in the middle of a war, [See Chief, A4]

Under homeless program, 40% back on streets

Growing number fall through the cracks of Bass’ \$300-million L.A. housing initiative.

By DAVID ZAHNISER

It was a risky move and Jonathan Torres knew it, but he did it anyway. He let an out-of-town guest stay with him in his room.

Torres, 40, had been living at the Highland Park Motel as part of Inside Safe, Mayor Karen Bass’ flagship program to combat homelessness. He and his neighbors, many of them from a downtown encampment, were told that visitors were not allowed.

Still, Torres kept having people over. After the third violation, he said, the facility kicked him out.

“It’s nobody’s fault but my own, but I just feel it’s unfair,” said Torres, who now lives in a tent in Chinatown. “In the real world, you’re allowed to have people come over. You have visitors. That’s part of keeping your sanity, you know?”

Los Angeles has spent more than \$300 million on Inside Safe since Bass launched the program in December 2022, clearing scores of homeless encampments and moving about 5,800 people into interim housing —

mostly hotels and motels. The goal was to get each of those people into permanent housing, typically taxpayer-funded apartments.

But even as the mayor’s initiative brings more people indoors, a growing number are winding up back on the street.

The longer the program exists, the greater the share of participants who have returned to “unsheltered” homelessness, according to monthly dashboards which were posted by the Los Angeles Homeless Services Authority, or LAHSA, and analyzed by The Times.

In 2023, at the program’s one-year mark, nearly 20% had returned to the street, according to numbers posted by LAHSA at the time.

Halfway into Bass’ four-year term, the figure had climbed above 30%.

In December, as the program finished its third year, about 40% of the people who had gone indoors — 2,300 of the 5,800 — were back on the street, according to LAHSA’s dashboard. That in- [See Inside Safe, A10]

L.A. homelessness agency singled out

Proposed budget aims to eliminate federal program that funds aid for homeless Americans. **B3**



GENARÓ MOLINA Los Angeles Times

JONATHAN Torres and his girlfriend, Jen Stoltzfus, eat breakfast in their tent near Chinatown March 7.

Microplastics are everywhere, even in the research labs

By SUSANNE RUST

As the science of detecting microplastics matures, so too does consensus about their ubiquity. Everywhere researchers have looked to find them, there they’ve been: In human brains and lungs; in breast milk and semen; in alpine snow and deep-sea sediment; in corn plants and beer.

And that, say researchers, is the rub: Scientists are not just finding them in our livers, arteries and ovaries. They are also everywhere else: in research laboratories, pipettes, refrigerators, solvents, bottles, goggles and the very lab coats investigators are wearing to find

them. So how do we know if those particles seen under the lens of a microscope are inherent in the sample, or contamination from plastic fibers floating in the air? Or from tiny particles that sloughed off from the inside of a bottle of solvent?

Microplastics scientists are keenly aware of the problem and urgently studying it, because the credibility of the research is on the line.

Their research suddenly skyrocketed in importance with the federal government’s announcement Thursday that it will begin actively investigating the wayward, potentially toxic particles in people and drinking water.

“We cannot regulate what we don’t understand,” Robert F. Kennedy Jr., secretary of Health and Human Services, said at a news conference.

Nicolas Leeper, head of vascular medicine at Stanford University, said he is “absolutely” concerned that “at least some part of what has been reported [in the scientific literature] may be spurious or artifactual.”

For instance, a 2024 headline-stealing study showed a relationship between microplastics found in the arterial plaque of patients undergoing heart surgery, and a higher risk of heart attack and stroke. [See Microplastics, A7]

Tranquility in a place of tragedy

After 5 ½ hours on backcountry skis, traversing the Sierra Nevada’s rapidly melting snowpack beneath a scorching spring sun, the guide at the front of our group stopped and went silent.

He dropped to his knees, bowed his head and folded his hands in prayer.

Out of breath, with my thighs burning from a long, steep descent, I was too tired to grasp what he was doing.

Then I noticed the flowers lying in a shallow depression in the snow.

We had arrived. At this remote spot in February, exactly one month earlier, 13 members of a guided backcountry ski trip were buried by an avalanche during a ferocious blizzard.

The peaceful beauty of the deadly Lake Tahoe avalanche site adds a sad twist to disaster

By Jack Dolan

REPORTING FROM DONNER PASS, CALIF.



DANNY KERN For The Times

BOUQUETS of flowers in an area where an avalanche took nine lives in February.

lanche during a ferocious blizzard.

Nine died, including three guides and six of their clients — local women, wives and working moms who had been friends for years — making it the deadliest avalanche in California history.

In mid-March, I joined a professional guide and an experienced backcountry photographer for the difficult trek to the site of the avalanche.

We followed, as closely as we could, the route the skiers took, starting at the trailhead near the summit of Donner Pass, named for the 19th century pioneers who got trapped in a blizzard there and, infamously, resorted to cannibalism.

We covered 10 miles, [See Avalanche, A8]

From Columbus to Chávez, few statues withstand the test of time

By PATT MORRISON

Try taking a census of the immobilized population of Los Angeles — otherwise known as our civic statues, rendered in metal or stone. Just try.

They’re not as immobile as you’d think. They’re here, they’re there, they move

from pedestal to pedestal. Sometimes they disappear altogether.

Right here in L.A., without journeying to Greece or Rome or the Louvre, we’ve seen statues with body parts missing. At one point, unknown someones snapped the nose off the statue honoring silent film lover-boy Rudolph Valentino, and

lopped the hands off the Lincoln Park statue of Florence Nightingale, a gift to the city in 1936 from a local hospital support group.

Alongside Lincoln Park, the small Parque de Mexico has what looks like a stubby Stonehenge of empty plinths. Stolen from its pedestals were an array of Mexican statues. [See Statues, A11]

Bruins have the fight for the prize

UCLA’s Final Four victory proves it won’t back down in big game, Bill Plaschke writes. **SPORTS, D1**

Order for student data is blocked

Federal judge rejects Trump’s demand for college applicants’ GPA and race. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Mostly sunny; warm. L.A. Basin: 83/59. **B8**

Opinion Voices **A16**
Obituaries **B6**

Gardening the California way

Glendale resident honors area’s history, replacing lawn with native plants. **WEEKEND, L6**

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